



Growth spurts

Between the ages of 11 and 15 years, females grow up to 3 in (8 cm) per year, with periods of rapid growth affecting different parts of the body at different times. The hands and feet usually grow first, followed by the arms and legs, with the spine and torso growing last. The hands and feet usually grow first, followed by the arms and legs, with the spine and torso growing last. These differently timed growth rates can cause clumsiness, as the muscles needed to keep teens balanced play catch-up, and the part of the brain that deals with spatial awareness adjusts to the individual's new height and body proportions.

Puberty problems

The average age for females to start puberty is 11 years old, but it can start at any point from 8 to 14 years old. If someone starts puberty before the age of 8, it's called "precocious puberty." If this occurs, it's best to see a doctor to see why the body has kickstarted puberty so early. It may lead to an early growth spurt that also stops sooner than it should, leaving them shorter than average as an adult. Similarly, if puberty occurs much later than 14 years of age, medical advice should be sought.

► **Different rates**
If a teen is concerned about their development, visiting a doctor should help reassure them.



Building body confidence

Feeling confident on the inside makes a big difference when a teen is dealing with the many changes taking place on the outside. The important thing is not to worry about what is happening to other people, because everyone matures differently.



△ Focus on the positives

Think about the incredible things the body can do, such as dance, run, and sing.

TEEN HINTS

Embracing change

- Your body lets you participate in exciting activities—focus on what it can do, rather than how it looks.
- Speak to yourself as you would speak to a friend, give yourself compliments, and avoid putting yourself down.
- Choose clothes that make you feel good, and focus on the parts of the body you like best.

PARENT TIPS

Supporting your teen

- Try to make this exciting life stage feel positive, in order to build your teen's self-esteem about who they are becoming.
- Providing your teen with all the information and practical stuff they might need can help them feel better prepared to manage the physical changes when they happen.
- If you're embarrassed about broaching these topics, acknowledge it to your teen – it will help your teen to see that being honest about their body is healthy.